

woodlands of her home state, Tubman brought hundreds of enslaved people across them to freedom in the North along the "Underground Railroad." Traveling mainly at night, and preferably during the winter, she fast gained a reputation among abolitionists, including John Brown, who called her "General Tubman." She may also have conferred with Brown in planning his famous attack on Harpers Ferry. She often deposited her "passengers" as far north as Canada after the lower Northern states became unsafe when the Fugitive Slave Law was passed. To the formerly enslaved people who owed their freedom to her in the later prewar period, she was simply "Moses."

When the Civil War broke out, Tubman was overjoyed at the prospects for the abolition of slavery, but became disappointed when President Lincoln seemed to reverse his anti-slavery stance by publicly reprimanding Union General David Hunter's "local" abolition of enslavement in the district of Port Royal, South Carolina. She became acquainted with Hunter while serving with a group of Northeastern abolitionists who had accompanied the Federal armies occupying the South Carolina coastal islands. There, she became indispensable both as a nurse, and as an intermediary between the officers and fugitive slaves who ran to the safety of Hunter's lines.

Tubman likened the need to abolish slavery to treating a snake bite: "You send for a doctor to cut the bite; but the snake, he rolled up there, and while the doctor doing it, he bite you again. The doctor dug out that bite; but while the doctor doing it, the snake, he spring up and bite you again; so he keep doing it, till you kill him."